

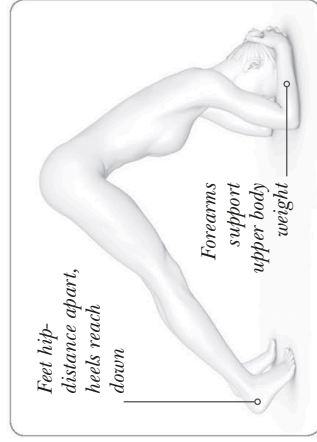
HEADSTAND

Sirsasana

This full inversion turns you physically upside down. A multitude of benefits can be ascribed to this pose: from helping you breathe more efficiently to strengthening your upper body—especially the muscles around your shoulder joints—and your core.

THE BIG PICTURE

This pose strengthens your arms and shoulders. Your core and thighs activate to stabilize your body at its center, preventing you from falling to either side. Despite the name, it is your arms that are supporting your weight in this pose, not your head.



VARIATION

This version of the pose has a reduced risk of falling and takes weight off your upper body. Push your forearms into the floor; lower your heels, and lift hips up and back. Allow your head to drop.

KEY

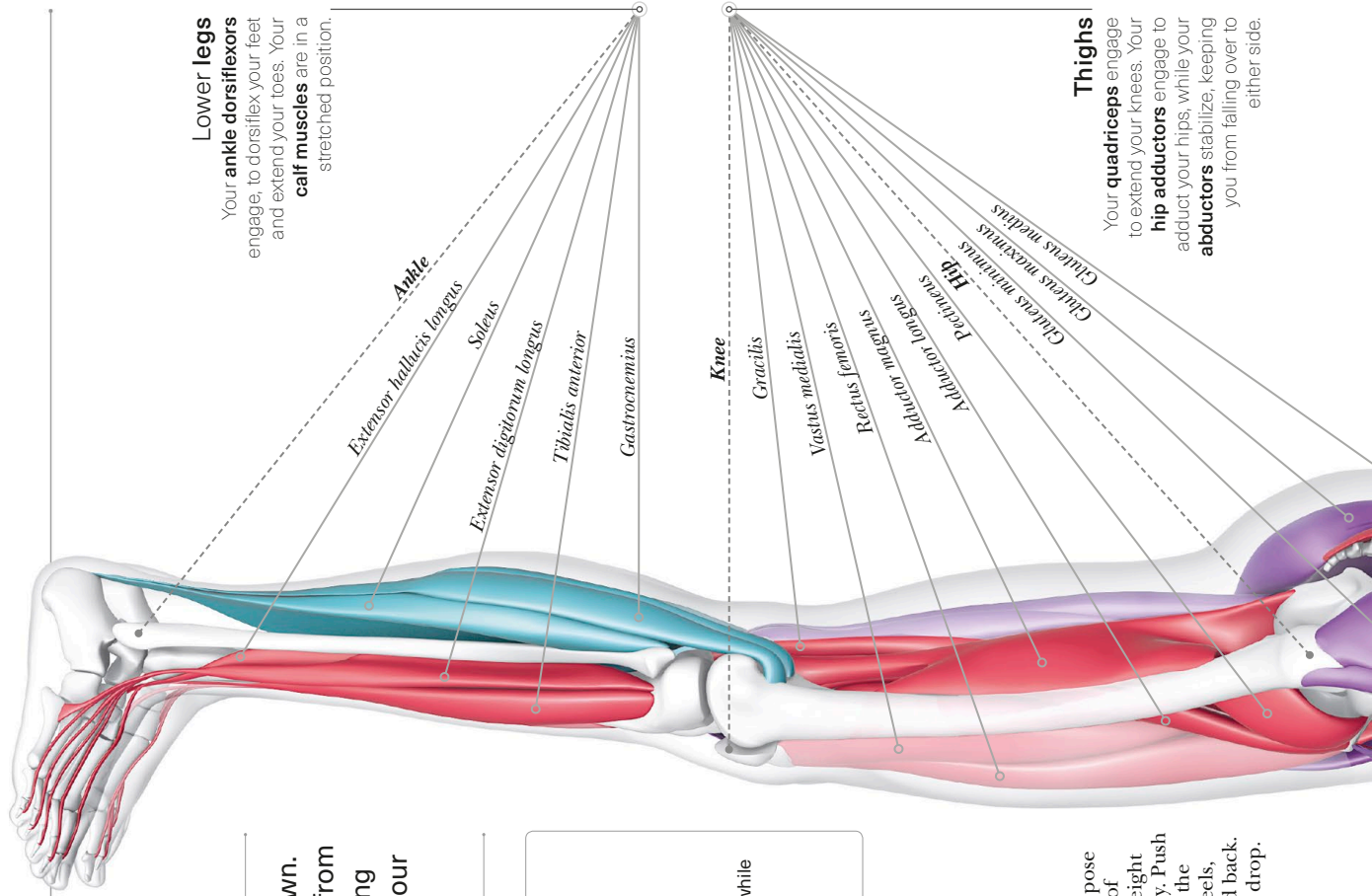
••• Joints

— Muscles

Engaging

Engaging while stretching

Stretching



Lower legs
Your **ankle dorsiflexors** engage, to dorsiflex your feet and extend your toes. Your **calf muscles** are in a stretched position.

Thighs
Your **quadriceps** engage to extend your knees. Your **hip adductors** engage to adduct your hips, while your **abductors** stabilize, keeping you from falling over to either side.